

MANDAR DEODHAR



PARVEEN SHAIKH, 37
Conservation scientist, avian ecologist, BNHS *Mumbai*

Protecting the Skimmer

WHAT MAKES HER A SHERO

Parveen's decade-long effort to save the Indian Skimmer, an endangered river bird, won her the 2026 Whitley Award

The Indian Skimmer is an unusual bird with an extraordinary vulnerability. With its bright orange bill, it flies inches above the surface of rivers, skimming the water to catch fish. But it breeds on sandbars and mid-river islands, where shifts in water flow, predators or even a wandering cow can destroy an entire nest.

For conservation scientist Parveen Shaikh, saving the bird meant understanding not only its ecology but also the people who live alongside it. A Mumbai suburban girl, who "was not born into nature", she discovered her passion for zoology in college. "I was always passionate about science. I developed my knack for zoology in college," she says.

Shaikh, who joined the Bombay Natural History Society (BNHS) in 2012, began work on Indian Skimmer populations along the Chambal river in 2016. Her 'Guardians of the Skimmer' initiative trained and incentivised local residents to monitor nests and protect vulnerable colonies. Shaikh says they now also help identify new nesting sandbars and prevent disturbance during the breeding season. Some even proudly refer to the skimmers as 'our birds'. Indeed, nest survival rate in the Chambal Sanctuary has risen from 14 per cent to over 25 per cent, while the local population has risen from about 400 birds in 2017 to nearly 1,000. In 2024 alone, the nest protection programme saved 500 chicks.

HER TAKE

"Do not give up. It might take time...but if you are persistent, passionate and hard-working, you will succeed"

Now, Shaikh is taking that model to a much more challenging landscape. Her 2026 Whitley Award (the 'Green Oscar') will support the expansion of the project to Prayagraj, where the birds face boat traffic, fishing, pollution and intense human activity, including the enormous crowds that gather for the Kumbh. ■

—ADM